pivotal actors in decision making can amplify their influence. For instance, weaker states often gain significant sway when elected to the UN Security Council or chosen to represent constituencies at the IMF. However, smaller states generally lack the ability to dominate IOs on the same scale as global powers.

The impact of co-optation on IOs can be profound, skewing institutional outputs toward the narrow agendas of populist states and eroding the trust of other members and external stakeholders. IOs may lose credibility as neutral arbiters, making it harder to attract funding, support, and cooperation. The process of identifying and reversing the damage caused by such internal subversion is often slow and fraught, leaving IOs bogged down in inefficiency and discord.

2.2.7 Toxic Communication

Populists can wield yet another powerful, cost-effective weapon in their battle against IOs: rhetoric. By scapegoating IOs for unpopular policies or domestic challenges, populist leaders shift blame and stoke public discontent. This strategy, deployed through speeches, tweets, and campaign slogans, often paints IOs as meddling elites disconnected from the needs of ordinary citizens (Vreeland 1999; Etter, Ravasi, and Colleoni 2019). Such rhetoric doesn't just deflect responsibility—it can make IOs more visible to the public and amplify dissatisfaction with their actions (Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019; Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023).

For populists, the appeal of rhetorical attacks lies in their simplicity and efficiency. Unlike the labor-intensive processes of cutting funding or creating alternative organizations, a scathing remark about an IO during a rally or in a viral social media post can be executed with minimal preparation and resources. These attacks allow populist leaders to score domestic political points by presenting themselves as champions of sovereignty and resistance to international elites, all while continuing to enjoy the benefits of IO membership.

Though less costly than many other weapons at their disposal, the issuance of hostile rhetoric can still be risky. If a populist's rhetoric contradicts their actions—such as cooperating with an IO while publicly criticizing it—their constituents may perceive such inconsistency as a